> shows how susceptible Mr Modi and his aides are to the unorthodox ideas of assorted cranks and oddballs from the Hindu nationalist movement to which the BJP belongs. The loudest backers of demonetization include a telegenic yoga guru, a chartered accountant best known for propounding the homespun economic philosophy of 'swadeshi,' or self-reliance, and a nongovernmental organization that wants almost all taxes to be replaced by a single levy on bank transactions.[24]

It does not take much imagination or powers of deduction to arrive at who the *Wall Street Journal* is referring to as the telegenic guru, the chartered accountant, and the non-governmental organization. Anyone who had watched the brouhaha during the initial days of demonetization about the brilliant minds that sparked the idea and inspired the Prime Minister would easily recognize these entities.

Over the course of the next few months, various media reports[25] suggested that Hasmukh Adhia, the Revenue Secretary in the MoF, and a few others were the core members of the planning team. They were reportedly supported by a young team of researchers, who worked from a few rooms in the Prime Minister's residence.

Adhia, a chartered accountant and graduate from IIM Ahmedabad, also had a PhD in yoga from the Swamy Vivekananda Yoga University, Bangalore. A Gujarat cadre IAS officer, he had earlier served as principal secretary and additional chief secretary in charge of finance while Narendra Modi was Chief Minister of Gujarat. It was rumoured in Lutyens' Delhi that though he formally reported to the Finance Minister, in reality, he had a direct line to the Prime Minister. Minutes after the demonetization announcement, Adhia tweeted from his own handle: 'This is the biggest and the boldest step by the government for containing black money. It is like a surgical strike on black money.'

In November 2017, he was elevated as the Finance Secretary. The person he replaced, Ashok Lavasa, was reportedly also involved in the planning of demonetization.[26] A former Madhya Pradesh cadre IAS officer, he was appointed as an Election Commissioner in January 2018, following his retirement.